Airtribe

Product Management Launchpad

Week- 4

Product Management Roadmap

PHASE 1
CRAFT
Modules 1–4

1. Fundamentals of Product Management
2. Product Strategy & Strategic Thinking
3. Problem Discovery, Market & User Research
4. Problem Framing & Prioritization
   WEEK 4

PHASE 2
CRAFT + AI
Modules 5–8

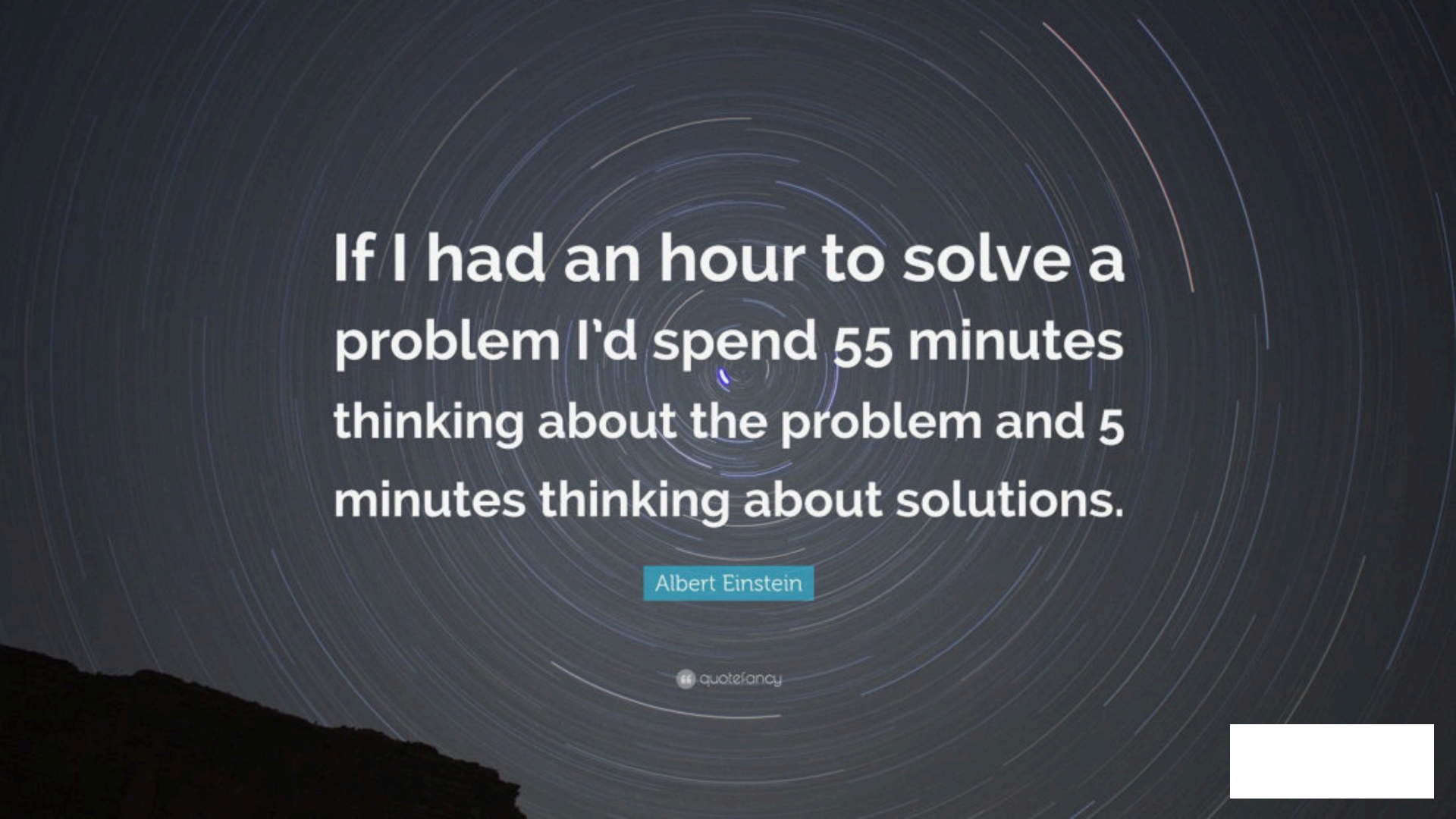
5. UX & Design Collaboration
6. Effective Communication as a PM
7. Analytics & Metrics
8. Product Launch, Growth & Monetization

PHASE 3
DEEP AI
Modules 9–13

9. Tech 101 & System Design
10. LLMs, RAGs & AI Foundations
11. Vibe Coding for PMs
12. Agentic AI & AI Systems in Production
13. Capstone Project & Interview Prep

What did we cover last week ?

1. Problem Discovery
2. Market research and Industry & Competitor Analysis
3. User research


If I had an hour to solve a problem I'd spend 55 minutes thinking about the problem and 5 minutes thinking about solutions.
Albert Einstein
quotefancy

Part 1: Problem Framing

1. Problem Discovery vs Problem Framing
2. JTBD
3. Why is Framing the Problem correctly important
4. Good & Bad Problem Framing
5. Why is it hard to Frame the Problem correctly
6. How to Frame the Problem correctly

From Research to Decisions

Problem framing turns raw research into a decision-worthy problem.



1. Research Signals

- Interviews
- Pain points
- Observed behaviour



2. Find Patterns

- Recurring friction
- Common needs
- Who is affected most



3. Frame the Problem

- Define the user
- Clarify the pain
- State the impact



4. Make Product Decisions

- What to solve first
- What to ignore
- What success looks like

Good PMs do not jump from research to solutions. They first frame the right problem.

Discovery vs Problem Framing

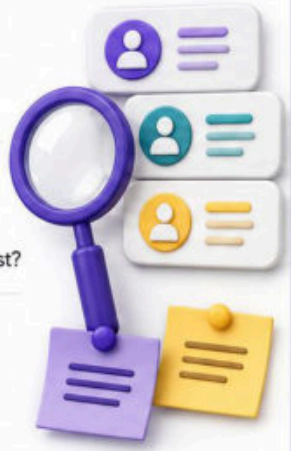
Discovery gives you evidence. Framing tells you what problem is worth solving.

Discovery

Goal
Understand users, needs, and context

Questions
What is happening? Who is affected? What patterns exist?

Output
Insights, pain points, behaviours



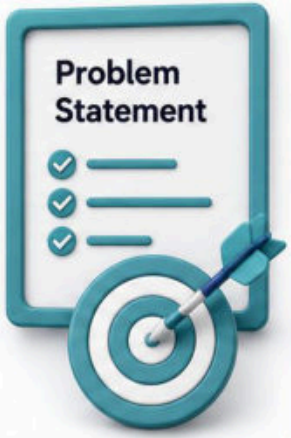
From insight to focus

Problem Framing

Goal
Define the problem to solve

Questions
Which problem matters most? Why now? What is in scope?

Output
Clear problem statement, boundaries, success criteria



Discovery explores the space. Framing narrows the space.

THE JTBD CONCEPT

The JTBD Concept

People don't buy products.
They **hire** them to **get a job done**.

Product Thinking	VS	JTBD Thinking
I sell a product with features.		I help the customer get a job done.



JTBD for an Amazon Search PM

A PM should define the customer progress the feature must improve.

Feature area: Search & Discovery / Search Results

When I come to Amazon looking for a product,
I want to quickly find options I can trust,
so I can buy with confidence without wasting time.

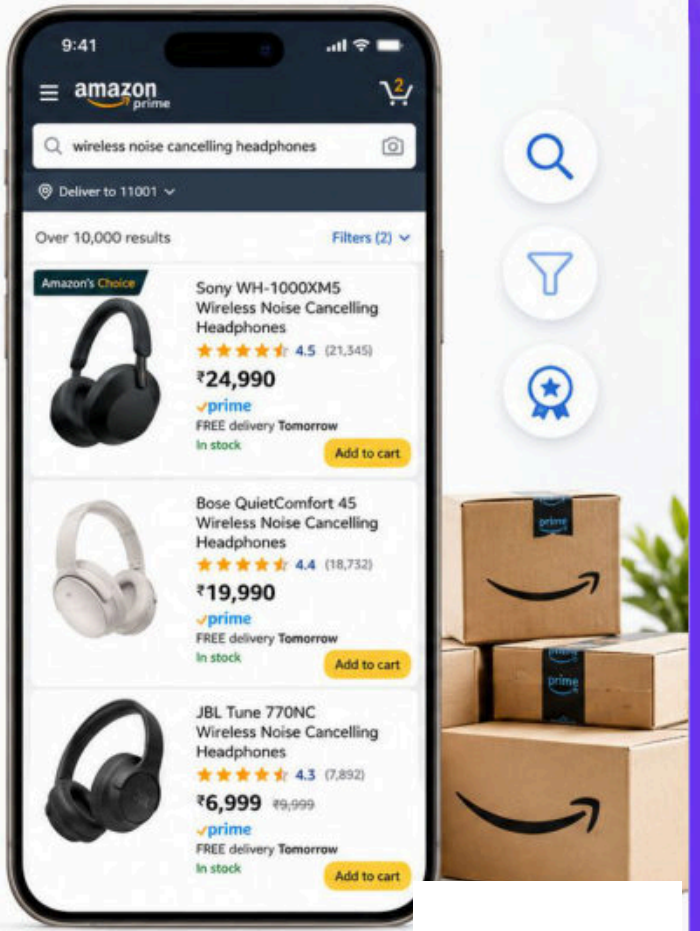
What this means for the PM:

1. **Help users find relevant products fast**
   search relevance, filters, ranking
2. **Help users evaluate with confidence**
   ratings, reviews, price, delivery promise
3. **Help users decide with less friction**
   compare, availability, Prime, add to cart

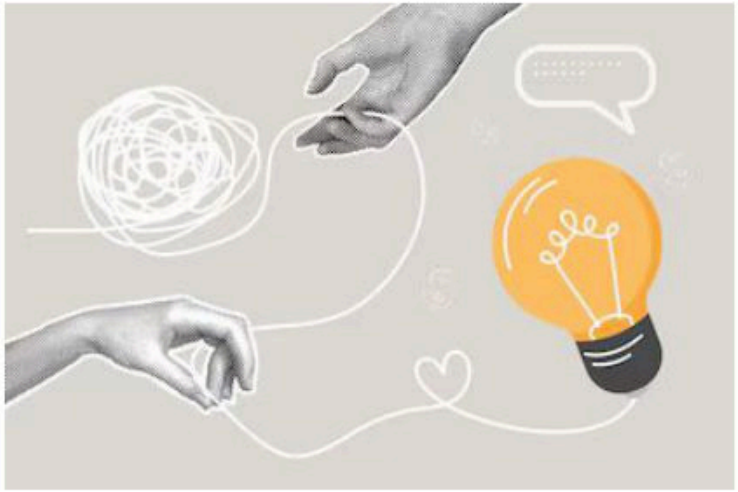
PM lens

The job is not 'build better filters.'
The job is 'help shoppers move from intent to confident purchase faster.'

JTBD helps PMs move from feature thinking to customer progress thinking.



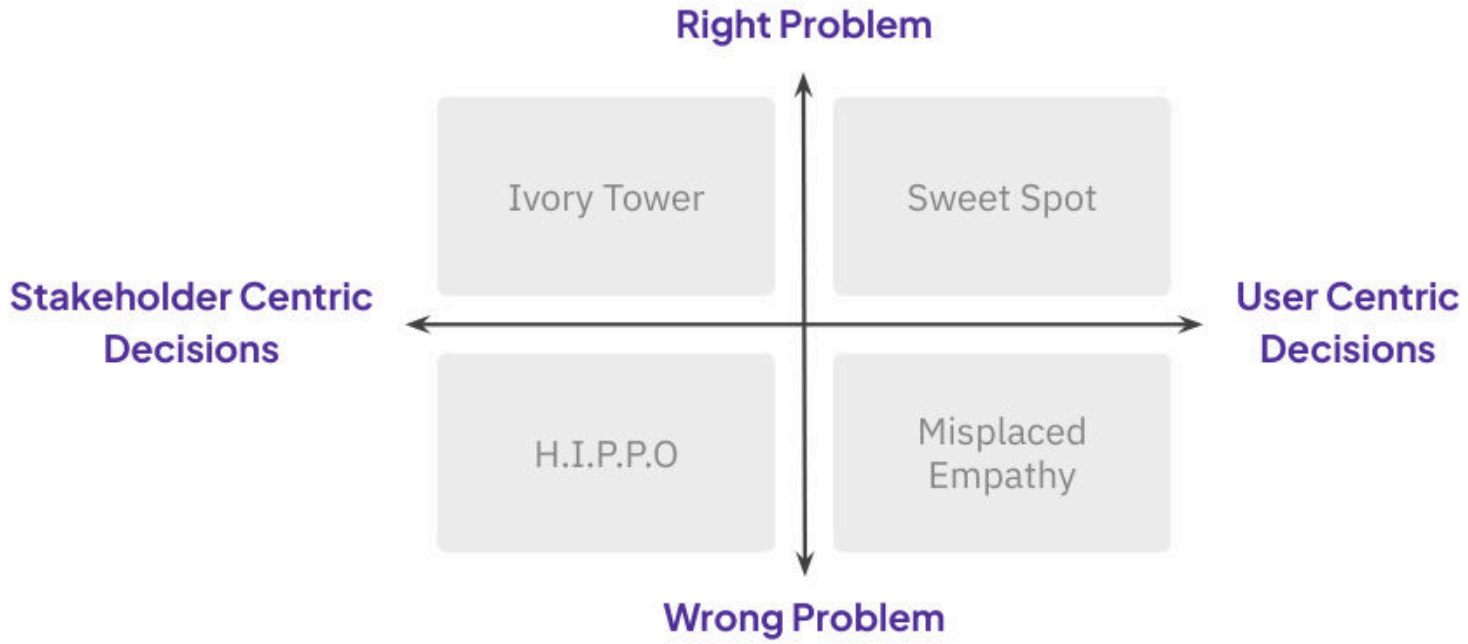
What is Problem Framing



Turning market and industry insights into an unambiguous, distilled, well-understood, and aligned problem, solving which gives you the best shot at success

Advanced: The act of defining what game you are playing before you start playing it

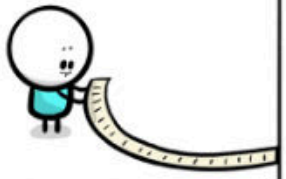
Good & Bad Problem Framing



More reading: https://www.designsprint.academy/blog/what-is-problem-framing

PRODUCT MANAGER'S GUIDE TO PRIORITIZATION

STEP 1
LIST ALL THE FEATURES.



STEP 2
SCORE EACH FEATURE.

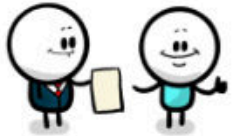
	R	I	C	E
F1				
F2				
F3				

workchronicles.com

STEP 3
THROW AWAY EVERYTHING.



STEP 4
BUILD WHAT UPPER MANAGEMENT TELLS YOU.



Good & Bad Problem Framing

Imagine this: You are the owner of an office building, and your tenants are complaining about how the **elevator is old and slow**. Several tenants are threatening to break their leases if you don't fix the problem.

When the problem is posed by like this, most people identify solutions like **replace the lift**, or **install a stronger motor**.

However, when the problem is presented to building managers, they frame the problem differently: **The wait for passengers in the lift is annoying**. And this unlocks a much more elegant solution: **Install mirrors in the elevator**. This simple and cost effective solution has proved wonderfully effective in reducing complaints, because people tend to lose track of time when they look at themselves.



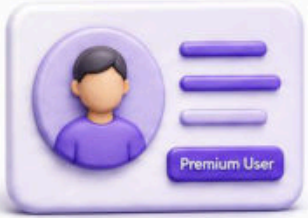


What Makes a Good Problem Statement?

A strong problem statement is specific, evidence-based, and focused.

1 Specific User

Name who is facing the problem.



2 Clear Pain

Describe what is broken or frustrating.



3 Visible Impact

Explain why it matters to users or the business.



4 Defined Scope

Set boundaries so the problem is solvable.



Simple Template

For [user segment], [current problem] causes [negative impact].
We should solve this because [user or business value].

A good problem statement focuses the team before ideas and solutions begin.

Weak vs Strong Problem Statements

The difference is clarity, scope, and measurable impact.

Weak

Weak example

Users are unhappy with checkout.

Why weak: Too vague. No user, no cause, no impact.



Weak example

We need a better app experience.

Why weak: Broad, subjective, and not actionable.



Strong

Strong rewrite

Working professionals placing lunch orders on weekdays drop off at the payment step because the fastest payment and saved address options are not surfaced quickly. This reduces successful orders and repeat use.



Strong rewrite

New grocery users struggle to complete their first monthly essentials order because reordering, stock visibility, and saved lists are unclear. This increases drop-off and missed repeat purchases.



If the problem statement is fuzzy, prioritization becomes fuzzy too.

How to Frame Problems correctly

1. Use the 5 Whys

- Begin with a specific problem and keep asking “why” to each of the successive answers you write down until you reach the root cause of the problem.
- Distinguish causes from symptoms or minor causal factors
- Answers should always be based on facts and data

Problem	There is a puddle of water on the floor
Why?	The overhead pipe is leaking
Why?	There is too much water pressure in the pipe
Why?	There is a faulty control valve
Why?	Control valves have not been tested
Why?	Control valves are not on the maintenance schedule

How to Frame Problems correctly

2. Use How Might We (HMW) statements

- Clearly define the problem or challenge with a concise problem statement
- Break down the problem statement into its key components
- Choose an action verb that prompts action and exploration
- Insert the subject relevant to the challenge or problem
- Add a provocative element to encourage creative and fresh thinking
- Generate several HMW questions by varying the action verbs, subjects, and provocative elements

Sample HMW canvas: https://dschool.sfo3.digitaloceanspaces.com/documents/HMW-Worksheet.pdf

How to Frame Problems correctly

3. Five Ws

Explore the Five Ws

1. Who?

Identify the people involved.

- Who is experiencing the problem?
- Who are the primary users or customers?
- Who makes decisions?
- Who benefits from solving this problem?

2. What?

Understand the challenge or need.

- What is the problem?
- What are users trying to achieve?
- What obstacles are preventing success?
- What outcomes are expected?

3. When?

Examine the timing and context.

- When does the problem occur?
- When is the need most critical?
- When do users interact with the solution?
- When should the problem be solved?

How to Frame Problems correctly

3. Five Ws

Explore the Five Ws

4. Where?

Understand the environment or location.

- Where does the problem happen?
- Where are users when they experience it?
- Where does the current process break down?
- Where can improvements create the most impact?

5. Why?

Uncover motivations and root causes.

- Why does this problem exist?
- Why is it important to solve?
- Why are current solutions inadequate?
- Why do users behave the way they do?

How to Frame Problems correctly – Exercise

Over the past 3 weeks, user signups have declined by 25%, resulting in reduced new user acquisition and impacting growth targets. The drop appears to be concentrated in the signup flow, but the root cause is unclear.

First-Principles Problem Decomposition

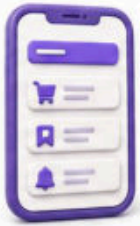
Break a messy problem into its fundamental drivers before proposing solutions.

Problem: Low repeat grocery orders



1. User Behaviour

- Users forget items
- No shopping routine
- Low habit formation



2. Product Experience

- Weak reordering
- Saved lists unclear
- Poor reminders



3. Operations

- Stock uncertainty
- Delivery windows
- Extra delivery charges



4. Business Impact

- Lower repeat rate
- Smaller basket size
- Higher acquisition dependence

Then rebuild from fundamentals

1. Identify root causes →
2. Choose the strongest lever →
3. Design the right solution

First-principles thinking prevents teams from solving symptoms instead of causes.

5 Whys vs First Principles

Both help PMs think better, but they solve different parts of the problem.

5 Whys



Goal: Find the root cause of an observed problem

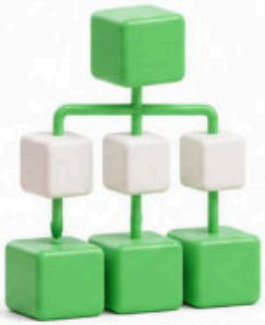
Best for: Bugs, process issues, drop-offs, operational failures

How it works: Keep asking "Why?" until the underlying cause becomes clear

Output: A sharper diagnosis

Example: Checkout failure → Payment timed out → Gateway retry issue → API timeout setting

First Princples



Goal: Break a problem into basic truths and rebuild from scratch

Best for: Strategy questions, redesigns, new product ideas, complex product bets

How it works: Remove assumptions and reason from fundamentals

Output: Better solution paths

Example: Low AOV → cart size, category mix, pricing, and purchase frequency

Use 5 Whys to diagnose why something is happening.
Use First Principles to *rethink what should be built or changed.*

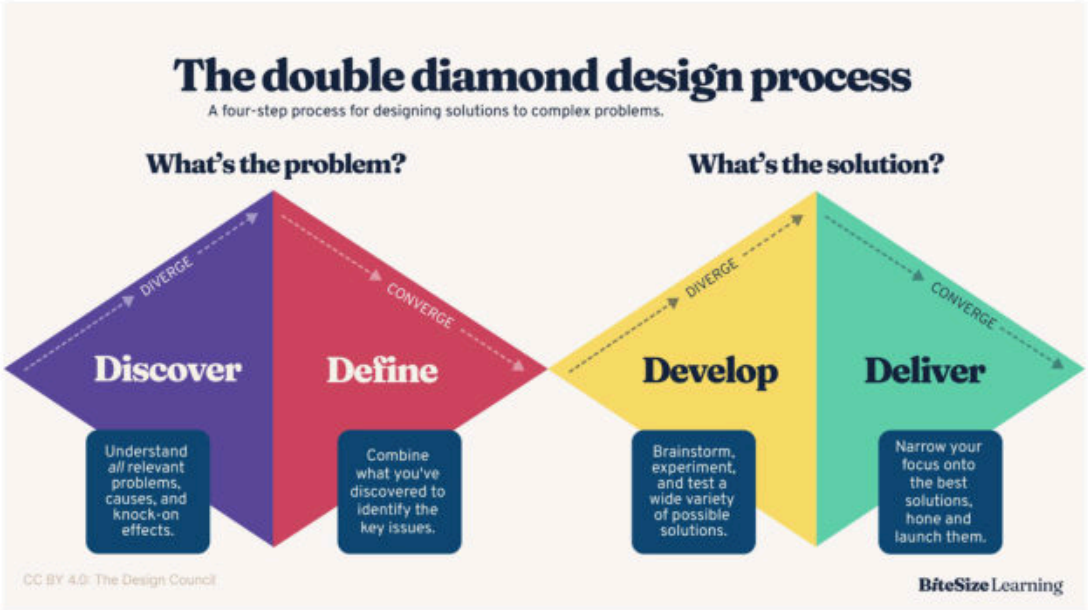
Thank you.

Q & A

Part 2: Solutioning & Validation

1. Identifying Solutions
2. Prioritizing Solutions

Problem Solving



Problem solving requires diverging and converging across the problem and solution spaces

More reading: https://www.designcouncil.org.uk/our-resources/the-double-diamond/

Problem Solving – Example

1. User Research informs you of a potential user problem



Qualitative user research

Average time taken to order

Quantitative user research

Problem Solving – Example

2. Frame the key problem well

5 Whys

Why are users finding it hard to order by themselves?

The Paradox of Choice*—An obsession with choice encourages users to seek that, which makes them feel worse off. Hence restricting the choice sometimes could be a way to make customers decide quickly and improve the overall experience.

Jobs To Be Done

When I am tired after a long day of work,
I want to order food quickly,
so I can eat and feel better

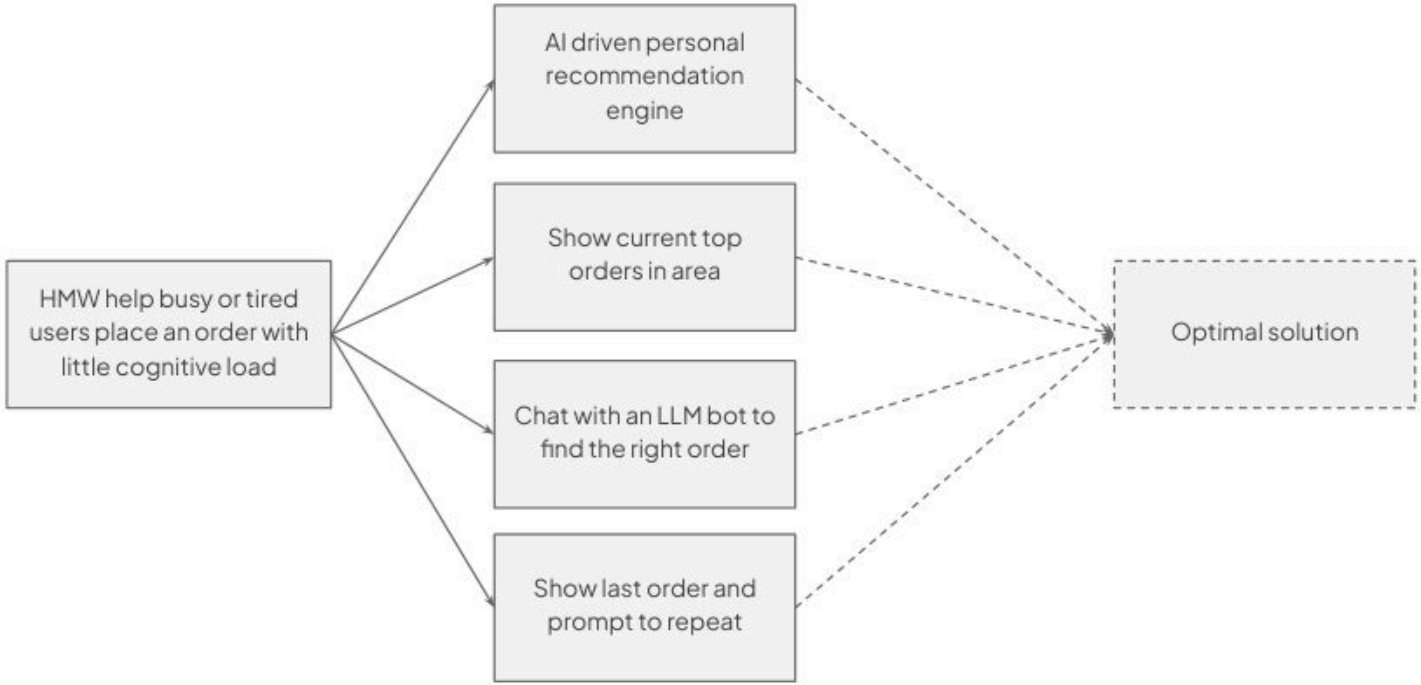
When I have a short break at work,
I want to order food quickly,
so I can eat soon and get back to work

How Might We help busy or tired users place an order with little cognitive load?

*Book: The Paradox of Choice: Barry Schwartz; Thinking Fast & Slow: Daniel Kahnemann

Problem Solving – Example

3. Identify possible solution approaches



USER STORIES

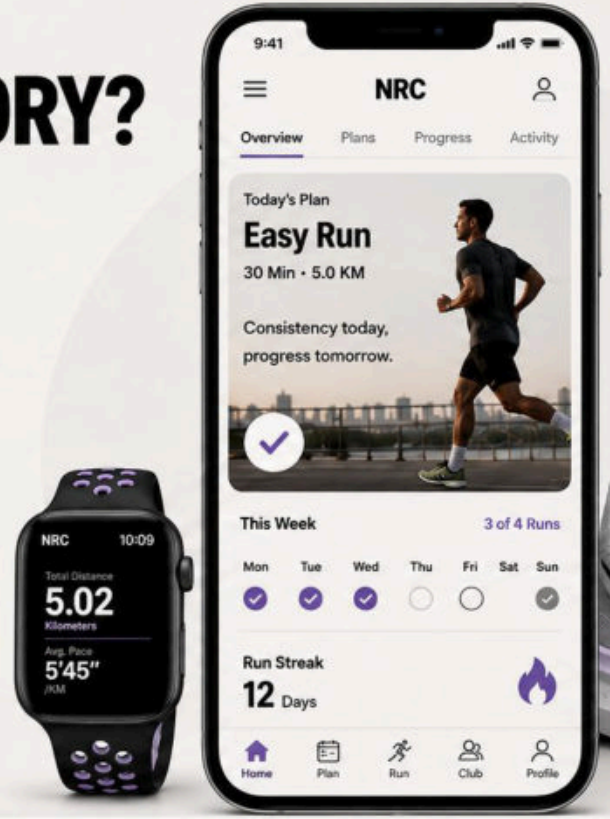
WHAT IS A USER STORY?

A user story turns a runner's need into a clear product direction.

NIKE RUN CLUB EXAMPLE

As a beginner runner,
I want a simple weekly running plan,
so that I can build consistency
without feeling confused.

Good user stories focus on the user, their need, and the value they want to achieve.





JUST DO IT.

TRACK YOUR RUNS
Map your route and distance.

SEE YOUR PROGRESS
Build streaks and stay motivated.

ACHIEVE YOUR GOALS
Celebrate milestones and improve every day.

USER FOCUSED
Keeps the runner at the center of *every* decision.

CLARITY
Helps the team understand what to build and why.

ALIGNMENT
Brings everyone together around the right outcome.

IMPACT
Leads to better solutions and a better running experience.

A clear user story keeps the ru
of eve

How to Write a Strong User Story

Nike example — turn a user need into a clear product statement.

As a [user], I want [goal], so that [benefit].

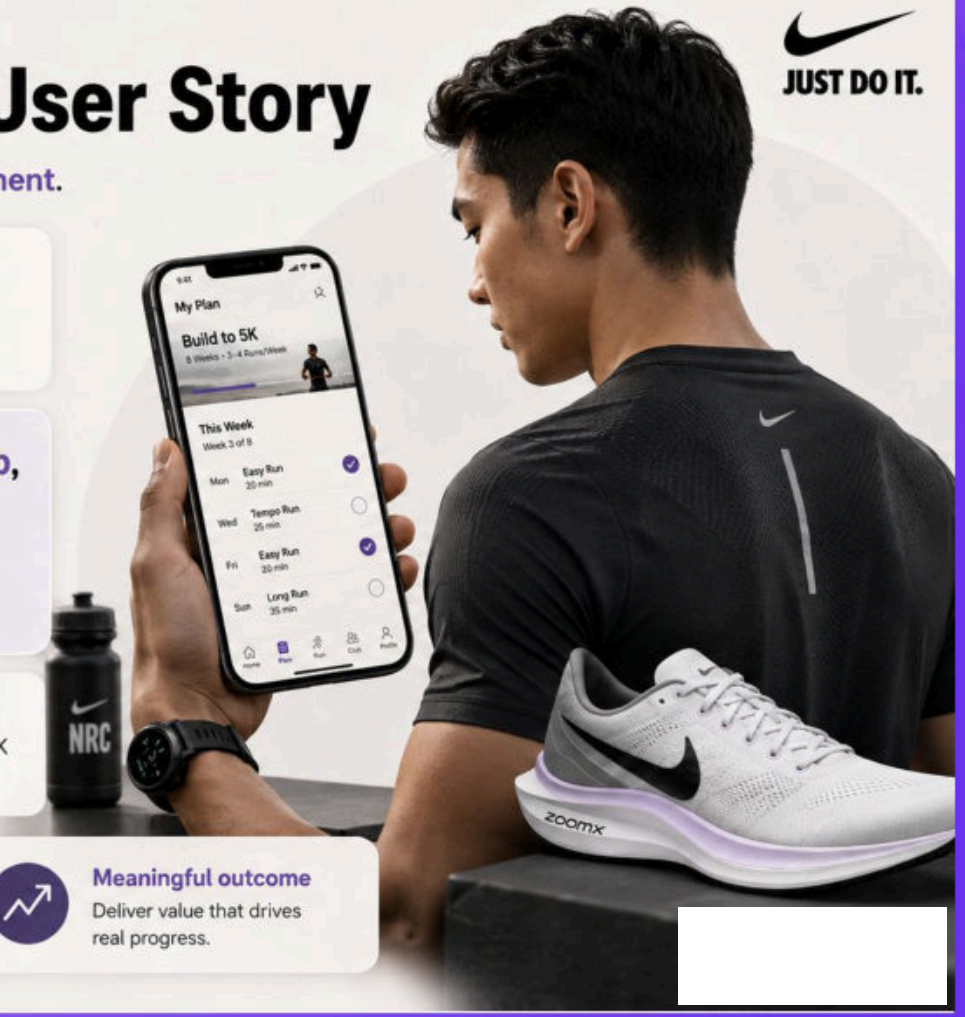
As a beginner runner using Nike Run Club, I want a simple weekly training plan, so that I can prepare for my first 5K with confidence.

User	Goal	Benefit
Beginner runner	Simple weekly training plan	Finish first 5K confidently

Specific user
Know exactly who you're building for.

Clear need
Define the need in simple, focused terms.

Meaningful outcome
Deliver value that drives real progress.



Validate the Story Before You Build

Nike example — check the user story with evidence before committing.

As a **regular runner**, I want **post-run shoe care tips** and **replacement reminders**, so that I can keep my shoes **performance-ready.**

1 Research Signals

- Runner interviews
- Search queries
- Repeat-run behavior

2 Prototype Test

- Mock reminder card
- Simple in-app tip flow

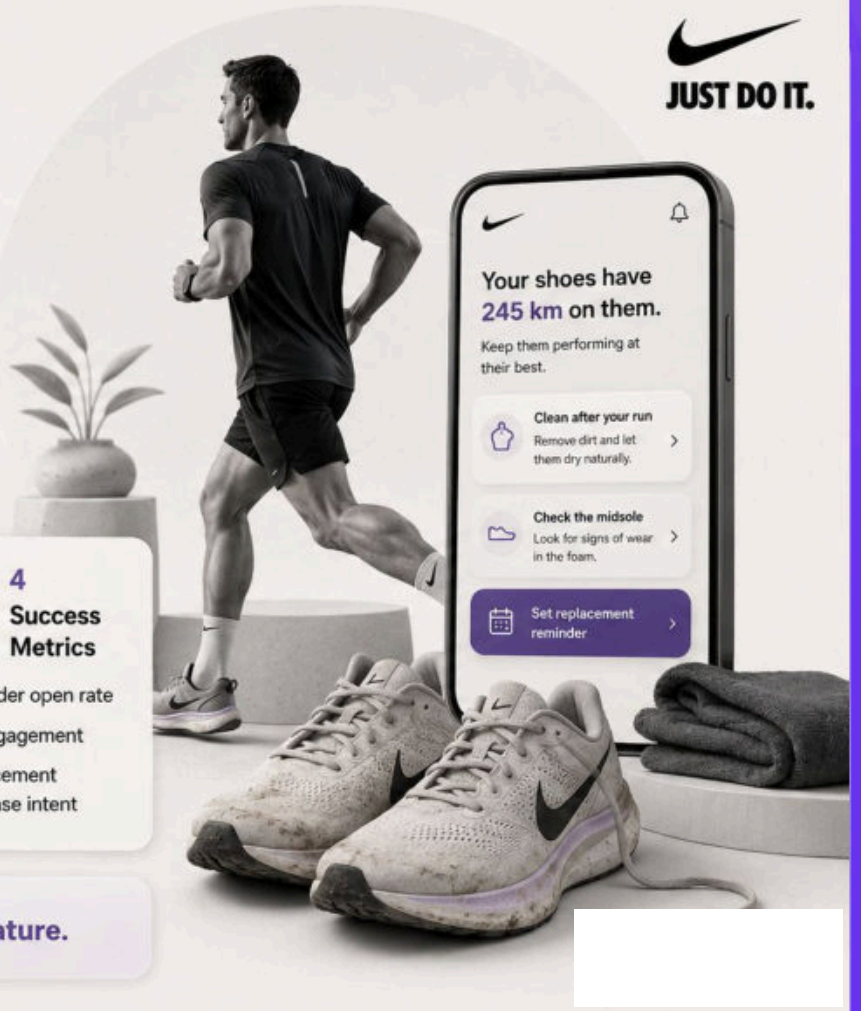
3 What to Check

- Do users care?
- When should reminder appear?
- Does it change behavior?

4 Success Metrics

- Reminder open rate
- Tip engagement
- Replacement purchase intent

Validate the problem, the moment, and the value — not just the feature.



Weak vs Strong User Stories

Nike example — the **stronger story** makes the decision clearer.

Weak Story

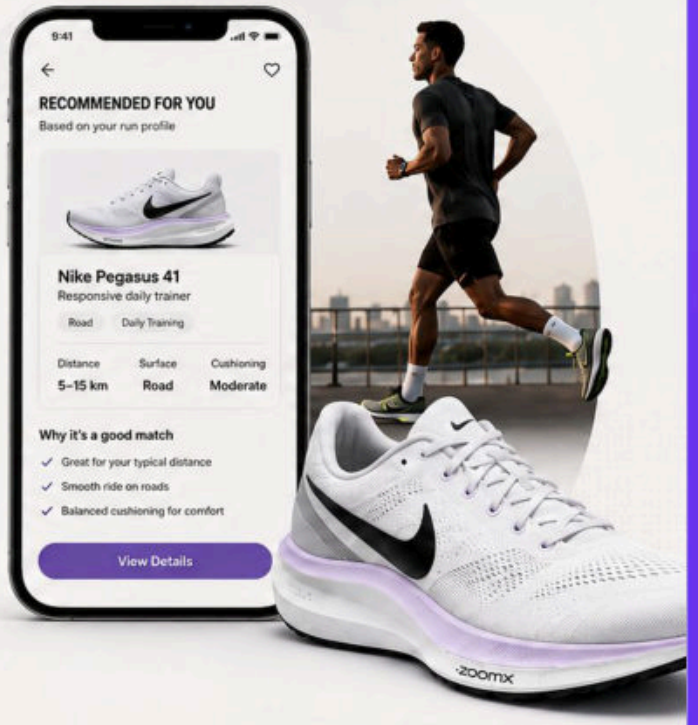
> Users want better shoe recommendations.

- ✕ Vague user
- ✕ Unclear action
- ✕ No clear outcome

Strong Story

> As a runner shopping on Nike, I want shoe recommendations based on distance, surface, and cushioning preference, so that I can choose the right shoe faster.

- ✓ Clear user
- ✓ Specific need
- ✓ Valuable outcome



A good user story helps the team understand who, what, and why.

From User Story to Product Concept

Nike example — move from problem to feature idea.

User Story

As a returning Nike shopper, I want Nike to remember my preferred shoe size and fit, so that I can reorder faster with less confusion.

Acceptance Criteria

- Saved size visible on product pages
- Filter by preferred fit
- One-tap reorder available

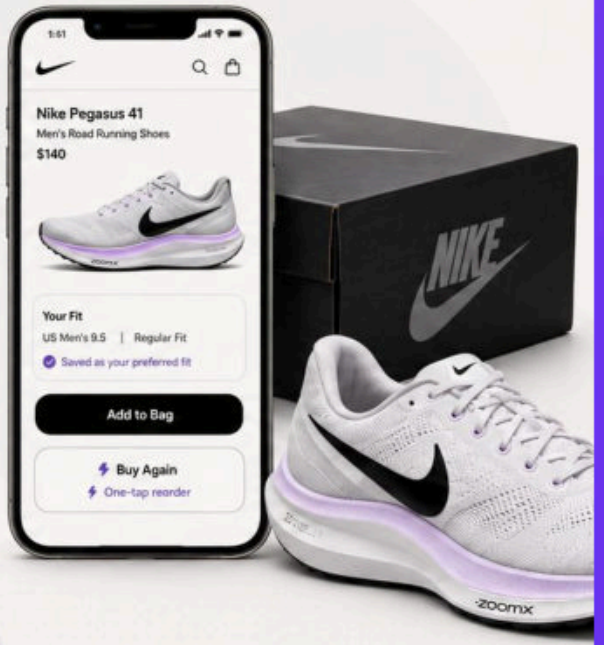
Product Concept

Smart Fit & Reorder

Personalized size memory and faster repeat purchase.

Expected Impact

- Faster checkout
- Fewer returns
- Higher repeat purchase



User stories become product concepts when we add scope and success logic.

Product Backlog vs Product Roadmap

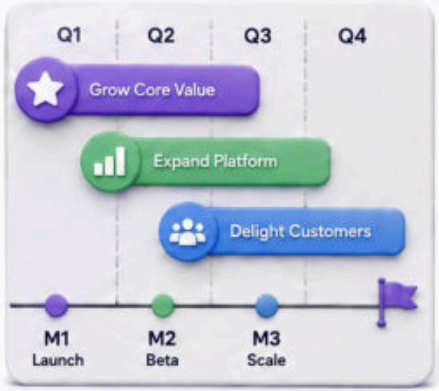
Both help PMs plan work, but they answer different planning questions.

Product Backlog



- Detailed list of tasks, stories, and bugs
- Continuously updated by the team
- Used for execution and sprint planning
- Prioritized at item level

Product Roadmap

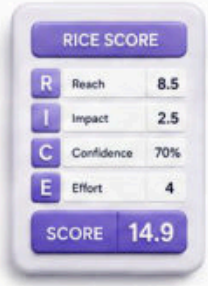


- High-level view of product direction
- Focuses on themes, bets, and outcomes
- Used for alignment across stakeholders
- Sequenced over quarters or milestones

Backlog = what the team may build next. Roadmap = why and when the product is heading there.

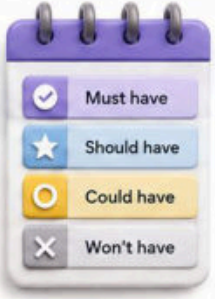
Choosing the Right Decision Framework

Different PM questions need different prioritization tools.



RICE

Useful when comparing opportunities using reach, impact, confidence, and effort.



MoSCoW

Useful when scope must be aligned into must-have, should-have, could-have, and won't-have.



Kano

Useful when understanding basic expectations, performance drivers, and delight factors.



Impact vs Effort

Useful for quick trade-off decisions when speed matters.

Weighted Scoring

Criteria	Weight	A	B	C
Customer Value	40%	8	6	7
Revenue Potential	25%	7	9	6
Strategic Fit	20%	9	7	8
Implementation Effort	15%	6	8	5
Total Score		7.75	7.55	6.80

Useful when multiple business criteria must be combined into one comparison.



PM Rule

Choose the framework that fits the decision, not the framework you are most comfortable with.



How to Prioritise – MoSCoW PRIORITISATION

MUST HAVE

- Non - Negotiables
- Minimum Viable Product (MVP)
- Can't deliver on target date without this
- Not legal without it
- Unsafe without it
- Without this project is not viable

Ask the question, "what happens if this requirement is not met?" If the answer is "Cancel the project" there is no point implementing a solution that does not meet the requirement.

SHOULD HAVE

- Important but not vital
- Maybe painful to leave out but the solution is still viable.
- May need some kind of workaround

A should have may be differentiated from a could have by reviewing the degree of pain caused by it not being met, in terms of business value of number of people affected.

COULD HAVE

- Desirable but not as important as Should Have
- Only do if there is extra time and budget

WON'T HAVE

- Won't have this time around at all
- Out of budget
- Nice to have but no real impact

Maximum 60% of total effort

Contingency

Maximum 80% of total effort | Business Care

Maximum 100% of total effort

RICE Framework

A simple way for PMs to compare opportunities and prioritize what to build first.

RICE Score = (Reach × Impact × Confidence) ÷ Effort



Reach

How many users will this affect in a given time period?



Impact

How much will it move the target metric for each user?



Confidence

How sure are we about the estimates and assumptions?



Effort

How much time or work will it take?



How to use it

1. Estimate each factor
2. Calculate the score
3. Compare options, then apply judgment

Quick example

Feature A

Reach:	1,000
Impact:	2
Confidence:	80%
Effort:	5
RICE Score:	**320**

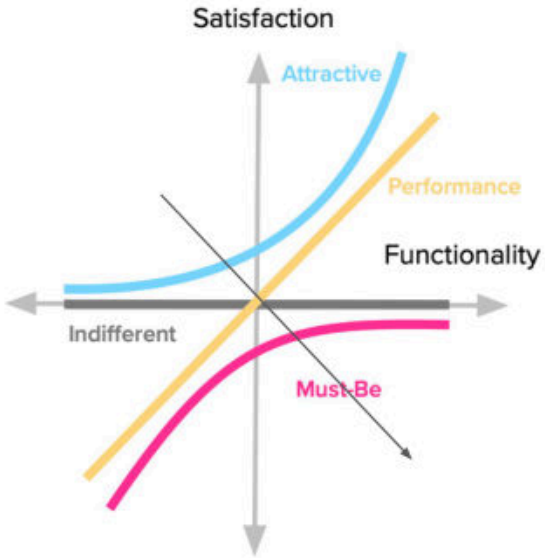
(1000 × 2 × 0.8) ÷ 5 = 320



RICE helps structure prioritization, but PM judgment still matters.

Prioritization – Kano Model

- User satisfaction (CSAT) with different degree of product functionalities / capabilities does not always scale linearly
- Product functionalities / capabilities can be divided into
  - **Must be / Must have**: Building these only give baseline CSAT but not building these can exponentially reduce CSAT
  - **Performance**: These features have a linear relationship with CSAT
  - **Attractive / Delighters**: Not building these have no impact on CSAT but building them well can exponentially increase CSAT
- This framework offers a good way to assess "Impact" of different types of solutions
- Tip: Over time the entire graph moves to the bottom right as customers expectations rise



More reading: https://thedecisionlab.com/reference-guide/design/kano-model

Prioritization Is Not Just Scoring

Frameworks create structure. PM judgment decides the final call.

What scoring helps with

- Creates consistency across ideas
- Makes trade-offs visible
- Brings transparency into discussions
- Speeds up initial comparison



What scoring can miss

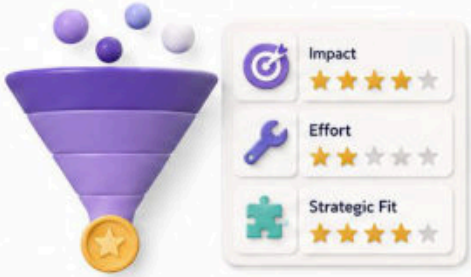
- Strategic timing and market context
- Dependencies and execution risk
- Learning value of a bet
- Stakeholder or platform constraints

Use scoring as an input, not as autopilot. Strong PMs combine frameworks with judgment.

From Prioritization to Roadmap

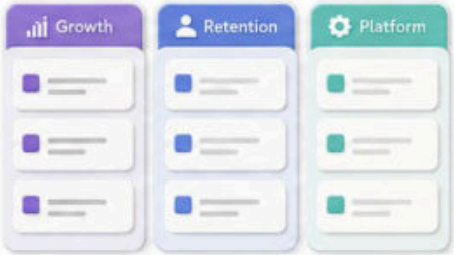
Prioritization decides what matters. The roadmap turns those choices into sequenced bets.

1. Prioritize Opportunities



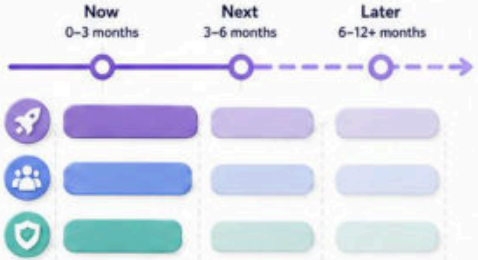
- Compare impact, effort, and strategic fit
- Evaluate urgency and user value
- Remove low-conviction work

2. Form Product Bets



- Group related work into themes
- Consider dependencies and team capacity
- Choose what goes now, next, later

3. Build the Roadmap



- Sequence bets over time
- Align around outcomes, not feature dumps
- Communicate trade-offs clearly

A roadmap is not a list of all ideas. It is the visible output of product judgment.

Deadly traps that affect prioritization

Recognize these patterns before they kill your roadmap.



The HiPPO Effect

Highest Paid Person's Opinion.

Symptom: CEO demands a pet feature; team drops everything.

Example: Yahoo's "Project Purple".

Cure: Depoliticize with scores. "Data says X scores 45, Y scores 120."



Feature Factory Syndrome

Symptom: Measuring success by shipping features rather than outcomes.

Example: Microsoft Zune vs iPod.

Cure: Reframe roadmaps as "Outcomes" (e.g., Increase activation to 50%).



False Urgency

Symptom: Fire-drill culture where important strategic work never starts.

Cure: Reserve 30% capacity for buffer so the 70% planned work isn't derailed.

Assignment

Take home assignment – Week 3

- ➔ Imagine you're a **PM at Zepto and** tasked to drive High Basket size (Increase average order value or cart value) .
- ➔ Perform primary or secondary user research
  - Segment users by shopping behavior
  - Identify blockers to higher basket sizes
- ➔ Frame the key problem(s) that need to be solved
- ➔ Figure the top effective solutions to increase AOV
  - Make sure to justify each idea with a clear rationale of why it solves the problem
- ➔ Prioritise the top solution(s) with justification/rationale



Appendix

Problem Solving – Example

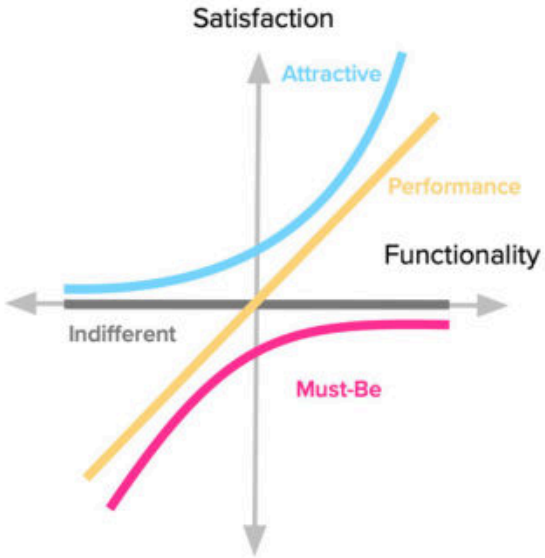
2.1. Identifying opportunities in the user journey

Scenario User wants to quickly place an order on Swiggy		**Expectations** Quick tasty meals	
Decide	Order	Wait	Receive
- Decide cuisine - Decide restaurant - Decide dishes - Decide quantity	- Verify order details - Confirm price and ETA - Apply coupons applicable	- Wait for order to arrive	- Receive the food
Opportunities There is an opportunity to make the Decide and Order phases less cognitive heavy. However, decision making phase has a more severe problem today.			

Empathy Map

Prioritization – Kano Model

- User satisfaction (CSAT) with different degree of product functionalities / capabilities does not always scale linearly
- Product functionalities / capabilities can be divided into
  - **Must be / Must have**: Building these only give baseline CSAT but not building these can exponentially reduce CSAT
  - **Performance**: These features have a linear relationship with CSAT
  - **Attractive / Delighters**: Not building these have no impact on CSAT but building them well can exponentially increase CSAT
- This framework offers a good way to assess "Impact" of different types of solutions



More reading: https://thedecisionlab.com/reference-guide/design/kano-model

Module 4 Summary: Frame, Decompose, Decide

Good PM decisions start with better framing, not faster solutions.

1 Frame



- Start with the right problem
- Separate discovery from framing
- Write a clear problem statement

2 Decompose



- Break the problem into drivers
- Use 5 Whys and first principles appropriately
- Convert problems into stories and backlog items

3 Decide



- Compare solution options
- Prioritize with judgment, not just scoring
- Translate choices into roadmap direction

The Module Learning Arc

Research → Problem Framing → Decomposition → User Stories → Prioritization → Roadmap

Final Takeaway

Strong product management is the ability to move from messy inputs to clear, defensible